reconstituted itself out of three very diverse parts which, for almost 150 years, had belonged to three different states (Russia, Prussia/Germany and the Austrian Empire). In addition, its Ukrainian minority was not treated properly and the country had territorial disputes, a major one with Lithuania (over Vilnius) and a smaller one with Czechoslovakia (over a coal-rich area). Foreign policy, though, was focused on averting the menace from both the Soviets and the Germans, so Poland signed treaties with both. Despite this, Stalin and Hitler attacked and partitioned Poland in 1939, making it very difficult for Poles to decide which of the two neighbouring states that invaded them was worst. And it was not only about occupation. In occupied Poland, the Soviet Union also launched a campaign of sovietisation, expropriating and nationalising big businesses.[52]

On the international stage, the alliance between the Soviet Union and Germany, as well as the consecutive partition of Poland, also needed some spin by the Comintern. Thus the word Fascism abruptly disappeared from Soviet vocabulary[53] and the official narrative became that of 'an imperialist war with respect to which the bourgeois of all the belligerent states are equally culpable.'[54] In words reminiscent of Putin's accusations against Ukraine in 2022, the Soviets talked about 'Fascist Poland, which has refused help from the Soviet Union'. As for France and Britain, they were said to have 'repulsed the Soviet Union in order to conduct a predatory war.'[55] In fact, as late as January 1941 French Communists were told by the Comintern that 'conditions for liberating French people from under the yoke of the occupiers have, however, not yet matured.' They were asked instead to focus on domestic collaborators.[56]

Equally dramatic were the developments in the Baltic states and Finland. The Baltic states gained independence while caught between Germany and the Soviet Union. Latvia and Estonia were internationally recognised in 1921. Lithuanian independence was only won after a bitter row with Poland, which held on to Vilnius, the capital of Lithuania. Independence was short-lived, however: in 1940, the country was occupied by the Soviets as part of an agreement with Nazi Germany. It was then overrun by the Nazis and once again occupied by the Soviet Union. It only regained its independence in 1990. The fate of all three Baltic states was similar. In 1939 Soviet foreign minister Molotov bluntly said to his Estonian colleague: 'The Soviet Union is now a great power whose interest needs to